

Linux Essentials

Content

Objectives

Key Terms

4.1

4.2

4.2.1

4.2.2

4.2.3

4.3

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Open Source Software and Licensing

4.1 Introduction

Software projects take the form of *source code*, which is a human-readable set of computer instructions. Since source code is not understood directly by the computer, it must be compiled into machine instructions by a compiler. The compiler is a special program that gathers all of the source code files and generates instructions that can be run on the computer, such as by the Linux kernel.

Historically, commercial software has been sold under a *closed source license*, meaning that users have the right to use the machine code, also known as the binary or executable, but cannot see the source code. Often the license explicitly states that users may not attempt to

Content

Objectives

Key Terms

5.1

5.2

5.3

5.3.1

5.3.2

5.3.3

5.4

5.4.1

5.4.2

5.4.3

5.5

5.5.1

5.5.2

5.5.3

5.5.4

5.6

5.6.1

5.6.2

5.6.3

5.6.4

5.7

5.7.1

5.7.2

5.7.3

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Command Line Skills

5.1 Introduction

Most consumer operating systems are designed to shield the user from the ins and outs of the CLI. The Linux community is different in that it positively celebrates the CLI for its power, speed and ability to accomplish a vast array of tasks with a single command line instruction.

When a user first encounters the CLI, they can find it challenging because it requires memorizing a dizzying amount of commands and their options. However, once a user has learned the structure of how commands are used, where the necessary files and directories are located and how to navigate the hierarchy of a file system, they can be immensely productive. This capability provides more precise control, greater speed and the ability to automate tasks more easily through scripting.

Furthermore, by learning the CLI, a user can easily be productive almost instantly on ANY flavor or distribution of Linux, reducing the amount of time needed to familiarize themselves with a system because of variations in a GUI.

Linux Essentials

Content

Objectives

Key Terms

6.1

6.2

6.2.1

6.2.2

6.2.3

6.2.4

6.3

6.3.1

6.3.2

6.4

6.4.1

6.4.2

6.4.3

6.5

6.5.1

6.5.2



Getting Help

6.1 Introduction

There are thousands of commands available with many options, making the command line a powerful tool. However, with this power comes complexity. Complexity, in turn, can create confusion. As a result, knowing how to find help while working in Linux is an essential skill for any user. Referring to help provides a quick reminder of how a command works, as well as being an information resource when learning new commands.

Previous

Next